position of authority within government, his apparent knowledge of the region, and his forceful personality meant that Curzon was adept at getting his way when it came to South Asia, often over-riding the objections of others. And when all else failed, he could always threaten to resign, as with the attempts to reform the Eastern Committee, or during the debates about removing Britain's troops from Persia. Curzon's difficult personality was in fact one reason that he had been passed over as prime minister in 1923.[9]

Given its subordinate position and its physical distance, if the Indian government was to have its voice heard it needed an advocate in London – and one who was strong enough to stand up to an overbearing foreign secretary. Unfortunately for Delhi, Montagu was to prove an inadequate ally. When it came to the Persian agreement, for example, the secretary of state allowed himself to be persuaded by Curzon rather than listening to his own viceroy. Luckily, in Afghanistan and India, the viceroy had more control and Curzon's attempts to impose his Persian-style policies in Afghanistan were rebuffed. Curzon's calls in 1918 to make the emir an official ally in the war, and his latter belief that India could retain some control of Afghanistan's foreign relations demonstrate that he not only got the Persia situation wrong, but entirely misread Afghanistan too.

However, even then Montagu failed to defend the Indian government's actions to the Cabinet. In his letters to Chelmsford, Montagu often complained that he felt the viceroy behaved unfairly towards him – making it known to the Indian public every time the secretary of state disagreed with the viceroy.[10] However, given what has been discussed, it seems hardly surprising that the Indian government often bridled at the lack of India Office support. The personal difficulties between Montagu and Chelmsford also did not help matters, and the secretary of state was not in office for long after Reading's appointment. Montagu's unpopularity with the Conservative party was a further problem for India. Despite all of his flaws, Curzon was extremely valuable to Lloyd George and to the coalition. Though he did not attract many friends, Curzon was a well-respected, prominent figure within the British political elite and an experienced statesman. Montagu was a Jewish Liberal, who appeared to take criticism very personally and often got far too emotional – a weakness for any politician.[11] His performance during the House of Commons debate on